sheffield connect

CONNECT WEEKLY

The Maps Project — Connection is the intervention

Issue 06 · week ending Friday 16 October 2026

themapsproject.com

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- ASCL's ruling council passed a motion of no confidence in Ofsted's leadership on 9 October, and NAHT followed on 15 October in backing ASCL, NGA and NEU's own statements — all pointing to a government-commissioned evaluation in which school leaders reported a serious wellbeing toll from the renewed inspection framework. Education secretary Lucy Powell has reportedly asked Ofsted to go 'back to the drawing board', with how inspectors weigh a school's context said to be the main sticking point.

  → **For your school:** *Nothing to change in your own inspection prep yet, but worth flagging to SLT and governors that 'context' is specifically where ministers want to see movement — directly relevant to how schools with higher-need cohorts get graded.*

- This year's key stage 4 data shows the disadvantage gap narrowing by the largest margin since before the pandemic, with 27.5% of disadvantaged pupils reaching grade 5+ in English and maths, up from 25.8%. NFER cautions that a change in how 'disadvantaged' is counted this year makes it hard to say how much of that is genuine improvement.

  → **For your school:** *A cautiously positive line for a governors' update on disadvantage — but caveat the 'why' if you quote the headline figure, since the measurement change is disputed.*

- The DfE has opened a consultation proposing a legal duty — changing 'should' to 'must' — for schools to set work for suspended pupils from day one, alongside steering suspensions towards serious cases only.

  → **For your school:** *Worth checking with your pastoral team whether your current suspension-work process already meets a day-one standard, since this looks set to become statutory rather than advisory.*

- Having written off an estimated £5bn of council SEND deficits built up by April 2026, government now faces calls for further support, as the OBR projects another £8.6bn will accrue before the current accounting override ends in 2028.

  → **For your school:** *No direct action needed, but worth keeping an eye on whether your local authority's SEND reform plan has been signed off, since some with the largest deficits have been told to resubmit theirs.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

19 Oct 2026 — Sheffield City Council's finance and performance committee considers releasing £602,000 of government funding for Lift Firth Park Academy's secondary expansion.

20 Oct 2026 — NGA due to publish full findings of its governance survey on the Ofsted framework.

28 Oct 2026 — Autumn school census deadline — the DfE says T Level and ILR data errors cannot be corrected after this date.

6 Nov 2026 — Deadline to notify the DfE of high needs place changes for 2027-28 funding allocations.

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

▪ **ASCL passes no-confidence motion in Ofsted's leadership.** ASCL's ruling council voted on 9 October that Ofsted's leadership cannot address the damage caused by the renewed inspection system, agreeing to survey members on an indicative strike ballot and calling for a pause to inspections. The trigger was a

government-commissioned IFF Research evaluation in which Ofsted's own summary put the share of providers reporting a negative wellbeing impact at around four in ten, rising to nearly half in schools — while separate NEU and ASCL member surveys put the figure for school leaders far higher, at around nine in ten. The gap is large enough that it's worth treating either number with caution until the full methodology is clear. (Tes)

→ **For your school:** *Nothing to change in your own inspection prep yet, but worth mentioning to governors that confidence in Ofsted's leadership — not just the framework — is now in question at national level.*

▪ **NAHT and NEU add their voices; Powell tells Ofsted to rethink how it weighs context.** NAHT's national executive resolved on 15 October to back ASCL, NGA and NEU's loss-of-confidence statements. Reporting this week suggests Lucy Powell has privately told Ofsted to go 'back to the drawing board', with schools serving more disadvantaged or challenging cohorts said to be faring worse under the report-card system. At Labour's conference she said she wants far more weight given to a school's context in future inspections, while acknowledging change can't happen overnight. (Tes)

→ **For your school:** *The story to watch most closely given the MAPs brief — any move on 'context' in inspection could directly affect how schools with higher-need intakes are graded.*

■ NATIONAL POLICY

▪ **2026 GCSE data shows the biggest narrowing of the disadvantage gap since before the pandemic.** The disadvantage gap index fell to 3.82 this year — its largest one-year drop since before Covid, though still above pre-pandemic levels. NFER's Jenna Julius cautions that the share of pupils recorded as disadvantaged rose from 28.2% to 29.8%, likely reflecting transitional Universal Credit protections, which muddies any read on how much of the narrowing is genuine improvement rather than a measurement effect. Flag: the exact scale of that measurement effect is disputed between analysts. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *Useful context for a pupil premium review this term — the direction is positive, but caveat the headline figure if you use it.*

▪ **Sector leaders gather in Birmingham as SEND reform looms.** The Confederation of School Trusts' annual conference ran 15-16 October under the theme 'Connecting', with sessions on how trust and civic leaders should respond to the schools white paper and SEND reforms. It landed in the same week as renewed scrutiny of trust CEO pay, with the DfE's approval threshold for salaries above £174,000 now in force. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *No action needed, but if your trust is affected by SEND reform, this week's sessions are a useful early read on sector thinking before the Education for All Bill progresses.*

■ INCLUSION & SEND

▪ **Councils press for more help as SEND deficits keep growing.** Having written off an estimated £5bn of dedicated schools grant deficits built up by April 2026, government faces calls from local authorities for a further two years of support, as the OBR projects another £8.6bn will accrue before the accounting override ends in 2028. Separately, councils with deficits nearing £200m have been told to resubmit their SEND reform plans before a bailout grant is approved — a reminder that this week's Ofsted row over 'context' and the funding picture underneath it are the same story from two angles. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *If your local authority is among those resubmitting its plan, worth asking directly what that means for specialist place commissioning in your area next year.*

■ BEHAVIOUR, EXCLUSIONS & ATTENDANCE

▪ **DfE consults on making suspension work statutory from day one.** A consultation launched this week proposes a legal duty for schools to set work for suspended pupils from the first day, not just the current five-day expectation, alongside guidance steering suspensions towards serious cases only. It follows May's statutory guidance update and sits against a backdrop of suspension and persistent absence rates still running above pre-pandemic levels nationally. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *Worth asking your behaviour lead whether your current suspension-work arrangements already meet a day-one standard, since 'should' becoming 'must' carries real compliance weight.*

SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

- **World-first social media trial launches in Bradford schools.** Around 4,000 pupils aged 12-15 across ten Bradford secondaries are being randomised this autumn into a six-week trial of an app that caps daily social media use, led by Cambridge's Professor Amy Orben with the Bradford Institute for Health Research. Researchers will track anxiety, sleep, bullying and school absence — directly relevant to the online-harms and misogyny concerns behind recent DfE safeguarding announcements. (NIHR Yorkshire & Humber)

  → **For your school:** *Worth knowing about even though it's a West Yorkshire trial — findings due next year could shape future DfE phone and screen-time guidance for secondaries generally.*

FUNDING

- **Autumn census and high needs deadlines land in this week's DfE Update.** The 7 October DfE Update reminds academies to check T Level and ILR data before the autumn school census (28 October) and R04 (4 December) deadlines, since errors can't be corrected in-year, and confirms the window for notifying high needs place changes for 2027-28 funding closes 6 November. (GOV.UK (DfE Update, 7 October 2026))

  → **For your school:** *Both dates are in the diary below — flag the 28 October census deadline to whoever holds your T Level and SEND place data now, not next week.*

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Sheffield plans secondary expansions to meet rising demand.** Sheffield City Council's finance and performance committee meets 19 October to consider releasing £602,000 of government funding so Lift Firth Park Academy can permanently expand, while Parkwood Academy's temporary 30-place expansion is also under review — part of a wider sufficiency push after officers projected a citywide shortfall of Year 7 places from 2027/28. (The Star)

  → **For your school:** *If you're near either school, worth checking with the council whether the expansion timeline affects your own admissions planning for 2027/28.*

- **23 more Sheffield schools in line for solar panels.** A new council climate bond will fund solar panels on 23 further schools, adding to an earlier round covering 21 schools projected to save around £1m over 25 years — though councillors say 36 schools remain on the waiting list. (The Star)

  → **For your school:** *Worth flagging to your premises lead if your school is on the waiting list, so you know roughly where you sit in the queue.*

DATAPOINT

3.82

This week's key stage 4 disadvantage gap index (National policy, above). It measures how many GCSE grades behind disadvantaged pupils are, compared with their peers, scaled across all subjects. At 3.82, this year's figure is the largest single-year fall on record outside the pandemic years — though it remains above pre-pandemic levels, and a change in who counts as 'disadvantaged' this year means some of the improvement may be a measurement effect rather than real progress.

Source: DfE key stage 4 performance, 2026 (Schools Week)

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.